A Beginner's Guide To GitHub Actions Secrets

Hardcoding passwords and API keys in your code is the fastest way to get hacked. GitHub Secrets gives you a safe box to hide your keys so your automated apps can still use them without showing them to the world.

What you'll learn:

1. Finding and Creating Your First Secret
2. Calling Secrets Inside Your Workflow
3. Passing Secrets Safely to Commands
4. Testing Locally Without Real Secrets

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Finding and Creating Your First Secret

To keep your passwords safe, you need to store them away from your actual code files. Go to your GitHub repository, click on 'Settings', look at the left sidebar for 'Secrets and variables', and click 'Actions'. Here you can click 'New repository secret' to add your keys safely.

```
$Repository Settings -> Secrets and variables -> Actions -> New repository secret
```

GitHub Actions Secrets: Store API Keys the Safe Way

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Calling Secrets Inside Your Workflow

Once your secret is saved, you need a way for your GitHub Actions file to read it. GitHub uses a special syntax with double curly brackets and the word secrets. This tells the runner to fetch the hidden value right before running the task.

```
env:
  API_KEY: ${{ secrets.MY_SECRET_API_KEY }}
```

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Passing Secrets Safely to Commands

Never put your secret directly into a shell command line because it might show up in the public build logs. Instead, pass the secret into an environment variable first, and then call that variable safely inside your build script.

```
steps:
  - name: Deploy App
    run: ./deploy.sh
    env:
      DATABASE_URL: ${{ secrets.DB_PASSWORD }}
```

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Testing Locally Without Real Secrets

When testing your GitHub Actions or scripts locally on your laptop, use a local file named .env to store temporary test keys. Make sure this file name is added to your .gitignore file so it never accidentally gets uploaded to GitHub.

```
$echo ".env" >> .gitignore
```

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Key Takeaways

+ Always use UPPERCASE names for your secret keys
+ Add your local config files to .gitignore immediately
+ Rotate your API keys every few months for better security
+ Use repository environments to separate dev and prod keys
+ Check your workflow run logs to ensure values are masked

Watch Out For

! Printing secret values using 'echo' in workflow steps
! Committing plain-text passwords directly into public repositories
! Naming secrets with spaces or special characters
! Giving everyone write access to repository settings

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